

Saving Private Public

I've written about privacy before as a column. Those of you who've been reading long enough will remember that I'm not the paranoid, tin-foil-hat-wearing type of geek. I don't really see what the big deal is for a government to go through my emails and even bank accounts and phone, if need be. Maybe I'm naive, but I've always felt that if you have nothing to hide, it doesn't matter who looks through your stuff.

No, I'm not saying we should all start changing clothes in public and embrace nudity! Neither am I saying that you should hand your passwords over to the government and give up on any hope of privacy. I'm just saying that unless you're pilfering government secrets, cheating on your taxes, involved with the underworld, not paying parking fines, cheating on your spouse, are a serial killer, etc, you've got no reason to fear a spybot – no, not the one made by the Safer Networking guys, I'm talking about automated surveillance.

Tragedies in India and around the globe (most recently in Paris) would suggest that we definitely need more monitoring and surveillance. It's not nice, no one wants it to be this way, but maybe we should accept that it's needed?

Whatever the case, it doesn't justify what organisations such as the NSA were doing, and neither was it right for John Brennan (the head of the CIA) to blame "unauthorised disclosures" (basically, Edward Snowden's infamous leaks) for the Paris attacks. Former CIA director R. James Woolsey, Jr. wasn't as diplomatic, telling MSNBC, "I think Snowden has blood on his hands from these killings in France".

As someone who lived through it in Mumbai, I can tell you those few days in November 2008 were terrifying and filled with disbelief. I'd rather give the government access to my emails and phone than risk another 26/11.

Of course, the pertinent question is: who watches the watchers? And yes, I think someone or something certainly should. There have to be checks and balances for any system, or else too much power inevitably corrupts.

However, there's a difference between watching everyone and being able to easily watch those you want to. What Snowden's leaks did was show the world that the NSA could break (and was breaking) encryption that was thought to be secure. They were (are?) monitoring email, SMSes, social media, etc. Not just of terrorists, but of the average Joe as well. That really pissed people off. The most affected, however, were companies.

We're talking Google, Facebook, Yahoo and the likes here. They had to ramp up security, if for nothing else than to atone for the embarrassment.

The CIA would have you believe that terrorists were using Gmail to casually chat about their next target. They want you to believe that giving up your rights will help fight terrorism, or else "the terrorists win!" They'll tell you that terrorists shifted to secure services, such as Telegram, all because of Snowden. They want you to believe that all of those innocent people killed across the globe, and especially in Paris, died because of Snowden.

It's hogwash, of course.

What the NSA and CIA (and perhaps such agencies in every country, including ours) really hate is being slapped on the wrists because of people like Snowden. The truth is, Snowden didn't cause the agencies to overstep their bounds – they did that of their own accord. If they'd been more careful and not just acted like dictators, they'd probably still have access to all that they did, and no one would be the wiser. I very much doubt that they'd catch any real terrorists like those behind the Mumbai and Paris attacks using a Gmail tap, but they certainly might have apprehended some of the people who try to go off and join ISIS's cause in Syria, for example.

That said, although more secure Google and Facebook servers are certainly desirable, going the other extreme isn't. We don't want to make it impossible for government security agencies to access critical data that may have been shared over the Internet by terrorists. The spying game has no time for red tape. Imagine if James Bond had to stop and get a warrant for everything he did... he'd never get anything done, Britain would always pay the price and no one would watch the Bond movies – if anyone still does these days.

I think we need to find balance, and to do that we can't vilify Snowden, and neither should we do that to our government agencies. There's a fine line between privacy and protection, and with so many walking that line like a tight-rope, there are going to be quite a few who fall off. Thankfully, this circus has a safety net (held by us) to give them a second shot at it, and that includes both, the Snowdens as well as the NSAs of the world... 



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